# Mick Harte Was Here

## By Barbara Park

## INTRODUCTION

*When I was a kid, I rode my bike all the time. I rode it all around my block and up and down my street. I rode it with my dad and brother to the local high school where we'd play a makeshift game of bike tag.*

*Sure, there was the occasional scare. Once I rode into a street without looking and a car had to stop quite short to avoid hitting me. My dad wasn't too thrilled about that, but nothing bad happened and it wasn't as if I was punished.*

*And not once, NOT ONCE, did I ever wear a bike helmet. At the time, I had some vague sense that I was invincible. Today, I look at that near miss with the car and silently shudder. I shudder, but not quite to the same extent as the speaker in*

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**NARRATOR:** I just want to say, right off the bat that this isn't the kind of story where you meet the main character, and you get to like him real well and then he dies at the end. I hate those kinds of stories. I don't want to make you cry; I just want to tell you about Mick. But I thought you should know right up front that he's not here anymore. I just thought that would be fair to you.

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It was a bike accident. It was about as "accidental" as you can get, too. Like Mick wasn't riding crazy. Or dodging in and out of traffic. And both of his hands were on the handlebars and all like that. His tire just hit a rock. And he skidded into the back of a passing truck. And that was that.

I'm only ten months older than he was. I was "planned." Mick was a surprise. He loved it, too. Being a surprise, I mean. He was always teasing my parents about it. Telling them that even before he existed, he could outsmart two chemistry majors with birth control pills.

I remember the first big caper we pulled together, we scratched the letters F-A-R-T in the new driveway that had just been poured next to our house. It was, without a doubt, the funniest thing anyone had ever done in the entire history of the universe. But it's amazing how a little fart in the driveway can totally lose its humor when your father sees it. He and mom stood us in front of them and made us "solemnly swear" to tell them the "complete and honest truth" about how it got there. Mick

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swallowed hard, took a big step forward, and told them "a monkey did it." Then – just to make the story even more believable – Mick said the monkey's name was Zippy. And the two of us had saved the day by chasing him "all the way back to Africa."

You know, I've heard that sometimes when people you love die, you forget their voices. But I haven't forgotten Mick's. Not yet, anyway. I have a weird kind of memory, I think. Like I've never once been able to remember my parents' anniversary in time to buy them a card. But I can still remember the exact conversation I had with Santa Claus when I was in kindergarten. He said, "Ho ho ho." I said, "Your breath smells." And he said, "Get down." It wasn't much of a chat, but the point is, it happened eight years ago and I still remember it like it was yesterday. I guess that's why it doesn't surprise me that I can still remember everything about the day of the accident.

See, Mick said he needed me to ride his bike home because he was going over to this kid Dillon Rigby's house after school, but I said, "Sorry. I've got soccer practice after school. Plus I've got a ton of books to carry home

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tonight." And he said, "Great, now I have to ride over there all by myself and I don't even know where the kid lives." And I said, "Aaah, no big deal. You'll be fine," and he said, "Gee, you're really cool." Then he just walked away. I didn't even get to say goodbye.

I'm running sprints at soccer practice when I hear the siren. It bothers me that I'm kind of hypnotized by the sight of an ambulance. I don't want to be one of those creeps who gawks at accident scenes. But I am, I think. Because as soon as I see the flashing red light appear over the fence, I can't take my eyes off it. The ambulance is getting closer to the soccer field now. But instead of speeding past, it seems to be slowing down. Then it slows even more and turns the corner in front of the building. My stomach starts to churn.

I don't like having the ambulance turn there. By now it should be speeding off to someone else's neighborhood. A neighborhood where I don't know anyone. Then all of a sudden, the door of the ambulance flies open and my dad comes rushing out and I close my eyes and I just wanted it not to be Mick. My dad puts his arms around me and

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pulls me close. Then he sort of cradles my head in his hand. Real gentle. Like I might break or something. Then in a voice so faint I could barely hear him – he whispers the words, "Mick's gone."

Yesterday was the official one-month anniversary of the accident. I used to think that anniversaries only celebrated happy things. But now I know that they're just a way of measuring time. I went to soccer practice after school. I didn't feel much like running though. The weird thing is, after practice was over, I didn't want to leave the field. All I wanted to do was sit on the sidelines and think about Mick. Right across the field from me, a group of workmen were putting up a new set of bleachers. They were setting them in concrete. So, it was pretty clear they were going to be there for a while . . . but I decided to wait them out. It was almost dark when they finished. I still can't believe no one stayed behind to guard the new sidewalk they just poured. I mean, you've gotta be nuts leaving wet cement unguarded at a junior high school. Especially if there's an eighth grader sitting across the field who's been watching you all afternoon. And I was

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totally calm when I did it. I walked over, bent down, and wrote, "MICK HARTE WAS HERE." Because he was. And for twelve years and five months, my brother was one of the neatest kids you've ever want to meet. And I just wanted to tell you about him, that's all. I just thought you should know.

## CLOSING – AUTHOR'S NOTE

*Head injury is the main cause of death in fatal bicycle crashes. Researchers tell us that if all bicyclists wore helmets, as many as one death every day and one head injury every four minutes could be prevented. I urge you, if you do not have your children wear bike helmets, please reconsider your decision. Today. Please. It's a matter of life or death.*

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

*2003 National Qualifier*
*2006 National Qualifier*
*2008 National Qualifier*
*2009 National Qualifier*
*2011 National Qualifier*
*2016 National Qualifier – MS*
*2019 National Qualifier – MS*
*2021 National Qualifier – MS*
*2022 National Qualifier – MS*
*2023 National Qualifier – MS*
*2024 National Qualifier – MS*
*NIETOC*
*IA State Qualifier*
*IL State Qualifier*
*IN State Qualifier*
*KS State Qualifier*
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